

NICC Core Competencies & Markers

Having completed an overview of how the work of NICC is organized, we'll now turn our attention towards our phenomenology and methodology of change.

NICC is an integrative model of care that brings together relational work, experiential technique, practical application of theology, a focus on the process of change, and healing itself. Our aim is not only to alleviate suffering but also bring about THRIVING!

While NICC is ever-evolving and is unique to each therapeutic dyad, the work is guided by a precisely articulated transformational phenomenology in its Core Competencies. This allows its supervision and teaching, which is always from video of actual counseling sessions, to be characterized by “rigor without shame”.

Supervision *markers* are the indicators supervisors are trained to listen and watch for to determine which NICC Core Competencies are evidenced in a recorded counseling meeting, and to what extent. The following markers are behaviors that represent demonstration of the Core Competencies in a counseling meeting at the NICC Certified level. These markers support a proficiency evaluation process that is fair, consistent, valid, reliable, repeatable, and defensible. The NICC Markers also support counselors and supervisors in identifying areas of growth and skill development through deliberate practice.

Deliberate Practice

Deliberate practice aims to move learning from declarative top-down, left-brain, knowledge to supporting an experiential and procedural competence. Its core principles are:

- a) The ongoing observation of one's performance.
- b) Establishing small learning goals that are just at the edge of one's current capacity.
- c) Repeated rehearsal of key skills.
- d) Assessing one's performance and ongoing development.

These principles form a 'cycle of excellence' to be repeated throughout one's career.

Overview of NICC's 18 Core Competencies

NICC is articulated in 18 Competencies, each with their own set of markers describing their specific interventions. The first thirteen (13) competencies are known as NICC's **Active Ingredients**. They are the 'secret sauce' that makes NICC special.

While not every marker for every ingredient will be present in every meeting, to the degree these ingredients are present is the degree the meeting reflects NICC or is NICCish. Recognizing that not every counselor who studies NICC will consider themselves a NICC counselor, or pursue NICC certification, to the degree the active ingredients are present in a meeting, amongst interventions from other models, is the measure of how much the work resembles NICC.

Competency number fourteen (14) involves aptitude for the **Ethical Practice** of NICC. Fifteen (15), covered earlier, denotes the **Mapping** the NICC counselor uses to locate herself in the work at any given moment. Sixteen (16) articulates NICC in its application to specific presenting issues, known as the **Protocols**. Seventeen (17) lists the specific **Skills** utilized, individually and in combination as ‘composite skills’ throughout the work. Finally, the eighteenth (18) competency elucidates the **Parallel Process** that is always at work in the counselor concurrent and complimentary to the participant’s process.

A reference chart of the NICC Competencies & Markers can be found in the Appendices.

Summary of NICC’s 13 Active Ingredients

1.	Incarnational - As an imitator of God, reveals God as He is and as He wishes to be known.
2.	Limited Reparenting - As a mature and wise other asymmetrically lead the participant in mismatching experiences that develop maturity in the 5 character domains.
3.	Embodied Spirituality - Gives close attention to the body and its relationship to mind and soul.
4.	BrainSync - Strategically uses limbic resonance (sharing), regulation (baring), and revision (shining) in service of the participants care.
5.	Thrive-Drive Spotlight - Notices, names, heightens, deepens, and celebrates Thrive-Drive experience in participants life.
6.	Go With Good - Leverages neuroplasticity to SNAG (stimulate neuronal activation and growth) the nervous system towards positive emergent experience.
7.	Self-Compassion - Expresses compassion and encourages self-compassion for all aspects of participants experience.
8.	Imagery - Leverages the nervous systems affinity for and neuroplastic capacity for positive change through the use of imagery.
9.	Feel-It-Thru - Prioritizes feelings and the processing to completion of feelings as central to the healing process.

10.	Mismatch - Identifies implicit/procedural learnings by way of their affective markers, activates them, and engages them with contradictory experience that results in transformation.
11.	Replay - Develops the self-reflective function and theory of mind in a participant while consolidating new implicit learning in explicit memory through bi-lateral stimulation achieved by alternating between experience and reflecting on experience.
12.	Play - Engages and reciprocates joyful / playful interaction and supports self-care and sabbath rest.
13.	Thriving - Facilitates and shares in the participants state of being deeply connected with self and with God.

NICC Core Competency Markers Chart

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1. Incarnational

Code	Label	Description
1	Incarnational	As an imitator of God, reveals God as He is and as He wishes to be known.
1.1	Love Participant	Counselor conveys to participant, through words, paraverbals, nonverbals, and action, genuine love, acceptance, and unconditional positive regard.
1.2	Love God	Counselor displays a love for God.
1.3	Apply Scripture	Counselor demonstrates a familiarity with and understanding of the Scriptures as applicable to participants life.
1.4	Share Values	Counselor exposes participant to his or her personal faith values and convictions without imposing values on the participant.
1.5	Pray	Counselor implicitly or explicitly prays for the participant and/or invites the Holy Spirit to lead the meeting.
1.6	Connect w/ Community	Counselor encourages participant to seek out and actively connect with other Christians.
1.7	Worship	Counselor expresses gratitude, thanksgiving, and worship to God with and/or on behalf of the participant.

2. Limited Reparenting

Code	Label	Description
2	Limited Reparenting	As a mature and wise other asymmetrically lead the participant in mismatching experiences that develop maturity in the 5 developmental domains.
2.1	Provides leadership & structure	Counselor provides leadership and structure to the meeting in service of the participant.

2.2	Develops Connection	Counselor facilitates a corrective emotional experience addressing a developmental deficit in a Connection playbook.
2.3	Develops Independence	Counselor facilitates a corrective emotional experience addressing a developmental deficit in a Independence & Mastery playbook.
2.4	Develops Reality	Counselor facilitates a corrective emotional experience addressing a developmental deficit in a Realistic Expectations & Limits playbook.
2.5	Develops Feelings	Counselor facilitates a corrective emotional experience addressing a developmental deficit in a Feelings playbook.
2.6	Develops Spirituality	Counselor facilitates a corrective emotional experience addressing a developmental deficit in a Spirituality playbook.

3. Embodied Spirituality

Code	Label	Description
3	Embodied Spirituality	Gives close attention to the body and its relationship to mind and soul.
3.1	Moment-to-Moment Tracking	Counselor, engaged in moment-to-moment tracking, notices a change in participants face, voice, or body that indicates emotional experience.
3.2	Entry to here-and-now	Counselor seizes an entry point for here-and-now experience, inviting body awareness / somatic noticing.
3.3	Listen to nervous system	Counselor encourages participant to value and listen to the wisdom wired into the nervous system by the Creator.
3.4	Vagal Noticing	Counselor facilitates participant self-awareness of (ventral, sympathetic, dorsal) vagal state.
3.5	Window of Tolerance Noticing	Counselor facilitates participant self-awareness of location in the window of tolerance.

4. BrainSync

Code	Label	Description
4	BrainSync	Strategically uses limbic resonance (sharing), regulation (baring), and revision (shining) in service of the participants care.
4.1	Sharing	Counselor, attunes his or her nervous system to the participants and reflects the participants experience through verbal, paraverbal or facial communication.
4.2	Baring	Counselor, via nervous system attunement, assists participant with co-regulation of intense affective experience accompanied with verbal, paraverbal, facially, or touch expressed support.
4.3	Shining	Counselor, interactively transfers positive affect to participant via verbal, paraverbal, facial, and body communication.

5. Thrive-Drive Spotlight

Code	Label	Description
5	Thrive-Drive Spotlight	Notices, names, heightens, deepens, and celebrates Thrive-Drive experience in participants life.
5.1	Notice Thrive-Drive	Counselor notices and names a Thrive-Drive expression in the participant.
5.2	Deepen Thrive-Drive experience	Counselor heightens and deepens Thrive-Drive experience.
5.3	Celebrate Thrive-Drive	Counselor celebrates Thrive-Drive strength in participant and expresses gratitude, thanksgiving, and worship to the Creator for Thrive-Drive.

6. Go With Good

Code	Label	Description
6	Go With Good	Leverages neuroplasticity to SNAG (stimulate neuronal activation and growth) the nervous system towards positive emergent experience.
6.1	Notice & Name Good	Counselor notices and names new positive emergent experience.

6.2	Heighten & Deepen Good	Counselor heightens and deepens new positive emergent experience.
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7. Self-Compassion

Code	Label	Description
7	Self-Compassion	Expresses compassion and encourages self-compassion for all aspects of participants experience.
7.1	Welcome Part	Counselor welcomes and encourages curiosity toward part.
7.2	Validate Part	Counselor validates the adaptive nature of part.
7.3	Reframe Part	Counselor positively reframes part in context of formative experiences.

8. Imagery

Code	Label	Description
8	Imagery	Leverages the nervous systems affinity for and neuroplastic capacity for positive change through the use of imagery.
8.1	Evocative Imagery	Counselor uses evocative imagery to heighten experience.
8.2	Imagery Naming	Counselor invites and facilitates the participants use of imagery to communicate experience.
8.3	Resource Development	Counselor guides participant in imagery to develop resources.
8.4	Processing Feelings	Counselor guides participant in imagery to process present feelings.
8.5	Processing Memory	Counselor guides participant in imagery to process past traumatic experience.
8.6	Priming Neural Pathways	Counselor guides participant in imagery to prime neural pathways for future positive experience.

9. Feel-It-Thru

Code	Label	Description
9	Feel-It-Thru	Prioritizes feelings and the processing to completion of feelings as central to the healing process.

9.1	Noticing Feelings	Counselor assists participant in noticing somatic features of feeling experience.
9.2	Heightening Feelings	Counselor heightens feeling experience.
9.3	Deepening Feelings	Counselor facilitates deepening feelings experience.
9.4	Naming Feelings	Counselor assists participant in naming one or more element of feelings experience.
9.5	Completing Feelings	Counselor facilitates participant staying with feelings experience until it completes.
9.6	Verifying Completion	Counselor verifies feelings completion by guiding participant to notice somatic markers of completion.
9.7	Discerning Action	Counselor facilitates participant discerning action to take based on the feeling.

10. Mismatch

Code	Label	Description
10	Mismatch	Identifies implicit/procedural learnings by way of their affective markers, activates them, and engages them with contradictory experience that results in transformation.
10.1	Reframe Experience	Counselor reframes participant experience in terms of unhelpful formative experiences, developmental deficits, playbooks, and/or wounded parts.
10.2	Follow Feelings	Counselor facilitates participant following feelings to near past / present problems.
10.3	Bridging	Counselor facilitates participant bridging near past to far past, activating formative experience memory network.
10.4	Identify Mismatch	Counselor facilitates participant exploration and discovery of corrective experience necessary to transform unhelpful formative experiences / care for wounded part.
10.5	Enact Mismatch	Counselor collaborates with participant to enact mismatching / corrective emotional experience and transform unhelpful formative experience / care for wounded part.

11. Replay

Code	Label	Description
11	Replay	Develops the self-reflective function and theory of mind in a participant while consolidating new implicit learning in explicit memory through bi-lateral stimulation achieved by alternating between experience and reflecting on experience.
11.1	Intrapersonal Reflection	Counselor invites participant to reflect on <i>intrapersonal</i> experience.
11.2	Interpersonal Reflection	Counselor invites participant to reflect on <i>interpersonal</i> experience
11.3	Name the Emerging	Counselor facilitates naming new experience emerging from a mismatching transformational experience.
11.4	Co-construct Anchor	Counselor co-constructs with participant an anchor for transformational experience.
11.5	Facilitate New Narrative	Counselor facilitates the construction and naming of the participants new narrative.

12. Play

Code	Label	Description
12	Play	Engages and reciprocates joyful / playful interaction and supports self-care and sabbath rest.
12.1	Share Joy	Counselor shares in a playful and joyful interpersonal interaction with participant.
12.2	Encourage Sabbath	Counselor encourages participant to notice the need for and engage in self-care around body care, sabbath rest, and or play.

13. Thriving

Code	Label	Description
13	Thriving	Facilitates and shares in the participants state of being deeply connected with self and with God.
13.1	Share Thriving	Counselor shares in and facilitates soaking up a thriving experience.

14. Ethical Practice

Code	Label	Description
14	Ethical Practice	Understands and consistently applies counseling ethics and standards of counseling
14.1	Demonstrates NICC Code of Ethics	Counselor demonstrates familiarity with the NICC Code of Ethics and its application.
14.2	Thorough Informed Consent	Counselor makes clear salient aspects of informed consent, including the nature of faith-based counseling, counselors training, licensure, and experience, and limits of confidentiality.

15. Mapping

Code	Label	Description
15	Mapping	Uses conceptual framework of NICC to identify current Stage of Counseling, Phase and Task of Course Work currently engaged in.
15.1	Beginning Stage	Journey Steps: #1: Defining the Relationship; #2 Goal Setting; #3 Connection; #4 Identifying Playbooks; #5 Identifying Parts
15.2	Middle Stage	Journey Steps: #6 Developing Resources; #7 Course Work
15.3	Ending Stage	Journey Steps: #8 Verification; #8 Celebration; #10 Goal Setting/End Work; #11 Final Meeting / Return to Step #2
15.4	Task #1 – Get Started (P1)	Check-In, Get-in-Sync, Headlines, Anchor Review, and Meeting Focus.

15.5	Task #2 – Connection/Start-Here (P1)	Establish safety and attuned BrainSync. (P1 – Defensive Phase)
15.6	Task #3 – Befriend (P1)	Greet, Welcome, and Befriend Defensive Parts (P1 – Defensive Phase)
15.7	Task #4 – Feel-It-Thru (P2)	Feelings Work, Imagery Work (P2 – Open-Hearted Phase)
15.8	Task #5 – Transform Wounded parts (P2)	Near Past and Far Past Bridging, Caring for Wounded parts, Mismatching Experiences (P2 – Open-Hearted Phase)
15.9	Task #6 – (r)eplay (P3)	Replay experiences feeling-it-thru and transforming wounded parts. (P3 – Replay Phase)
15.10	Task #7 – Anchor (P3)	Anchor transformation. (P3 – Replay Phase)
15.11	Task #8 – Soak It Up (P4)	Facilitate Soaking Up Thriving experience. (P4 – Thriving Phase)
15.12	Task #9 – Wrap-Up	Meeting Replay, Anchor Review, Housekeeping.

16. Protocols

Code	Label	Description
16	Protocols	Understands and consistently applies the appropriate counseling protocol for the presenting concern.
16.1	Individual (I)	Counselor demonstrates familiarity with the NICC Individual (I) Protocols and their application.
16.2	Marriage-Communication (M-C)	Counselor demonstrates familiarity with the NICC Marriage-Communication (M-C) Protocols and their application.
16.3	Marriage-Infidelity (M-I)	Counselor demonstrates familiarity with the NICC Marriage-Infidelity (M-I) Protocols and their application.
16.4	Marriage-Premarital (M-P)	Counselor demonstrates familiarity with the NICC Marriage-Premarital (M-P) Protocols and their application.
16.5	Marriage-Sex Therapy (M-S)	Counselor demonstrates familiarity with the NICC Marriage-Sex Therapy (M-S) Protocols and their application.
16.6	Family (F)	Counselor demonstrates familiarity with the NICC Family (F) Protocols and their application.

17. Core Skills

Code	Label	Description
17	Core Skills	The irreducible skills of NICC expressed in a variety of strategies and composite skills.
17.1	Welcoming	Invite with genuine curiosity and compassion participants to connect with and share their experience, with curiosity and self-compassion.
17.2	Delighting	Through Shining sharing encouragement and support by asserting as fact something positive about the participant or agreeing with a positive message asserted by them.
17.3	Noticing	Moment-to-moment tracking with mindful awareness here-and-now intrapersonal and interpersonal experience.
17.4	Naming	Assigning language to an experience.
17.5	Heightening	Intensifying with emotional imagery and language participants experience (Repeat, Image, Simple, Slow, Soft, Clients Words; R.I.S.S.S.C).
17.6	Deepening	Focusing the participant on specific somatic or feeling experiences to elaborate the experience, strengthen neuropathways, and increase myelination of neuronal axons.
17.7	Validating	Acknowledge, legitimize, and accept the participants feelings, thoughts, and/or beliefs as they experience it.
17.8	Reframing	Articulate the participants experience within the context of their playbooks, formational experiences, and Thrive-Drive longings.
17.9	Restructuring	Offering a directive to participants which builds on new emotional experience and seeks to create a mismatching experience, linking intrapsychic work to interpersonal action.
17.10	Self-Disclosure	Judicious sharing of counselor's own experience with and in service of the participant.
17.11	Teaching	Educating the participant on matters relevant to their care, theology, and neuroscience.

17.12	Silence	Engagement of non-verbal BrainSync creating space for the participants experience to unfold.
17.13	Pacing	The strategic use of mirroring and limbic revision via verbal tone, volume, and tempo to upregulate, match, or s-l-o-w down here-and-now process.

18. Parallel Process

Code	Label	Description
18	Parallel Process	The counselors experience during a meeting in interaction with the participant; triggered, parallel or complementary.
18.1	Attuned/Sharing/Baring	Connected and parallel or complimentary to the participant's experience. (Interpersonal)
18.2	Mis-Attuned / Rupture	Loss of BrainSync and/or injury to Connection. (Interpersonal)
18.3	Re-Attuning / Repair	Acknowledging errors and breaches in the alliance and moving to regain attunement and restore connection. (Interpersonal)
18.4	Triggered	Dysregulated and distracted with counselors own sympathetic or dorsal vagal state. (Intrapsychic)
18.5	Self-Regulating	Mindfully aware of self-state and engaging in intrapsychic or interpersonal action to regulate counselor's own nervous system. (Intrapsychic)